

iProtectYou Web Filter

This software from www.softforyou.com is another small download—just 2.57 MB—and costs \$34.95 (Rs 1,600). I used the 14-day free trial to test it, and found that, as usual, installation and configuration was easy.

Like CYBERSitter, it does offer e-mail filtering, but defaults to not filtering incoming mails, because with the amount of spam we all receive, it will have to keep blocking your mail client. These software can filter your mail, but you'd be a lot better off installing a good, free spam filter that is made to do that job.

You can set the program to auto-update itself, and also have the option of e-mailing scheduled reports to yourself. You can even play the role of a paranoid parent and have the software e-mail you every time it blocks something—along with a screenshot!

Instead of time management, this software lets you set traffic limitations—so you can decide that your 10-year-old gets 10 MB of surfing time a day, while your 15-year-old might get 20 MB—provided they have their own user accounts on the PC. You can also set the usage allowance per user, per day of the week!

The software blocks all negative content well, and popped up a little “Access Restricted” warning at the bottom right when I tried regular porn sites. It was easy to fool the software in a Google Image search to get images of nudity. It was not very good with non-English sites: its database doesn't seem to include as many foreign sites as the other software in this test do.

To its credit, the software allowed a site which had adult-oriented ads to be displayed, while blocking just the ads. This may not be a comfort for paranoid parents, but it seemed a good feature to me.

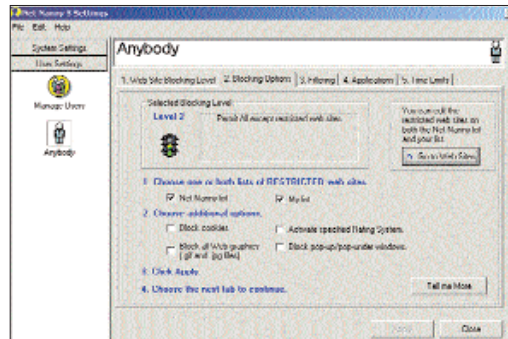
Security-wise, the software loses miserably because it's easy to End Task the application using the Task Manager. I can't understand why the authors of the software didn't look at this!

Overall, a good software that blocks content well, and smartly, but with its poor security it's not something you want to buy—especially if you are one of the many families where your kids know more than you about computers!



iProtectYou has a lot of features such as e-mail notification and filtering, but it couldn't block any images or content (right) from our “Innocuous Sites” list

**Net Nanny's
“block
everything or
nothing”
philosophy is
certainly not
what you're
looking for in a
content filter**



**NetNanny does not have
too many blocking
options, except for a
“Block all Web Graphics”
option that seems a little
too severe.**



Net Nanny

The most famous Internet nanny of all time, this software is easily the most popular of them all. The Nanny has put on a lot of weight over the years though, and at 22.8 MB, she was the fattest download in this test. And at the standard price of \$39.95 (Rs 1,800), she doesn't come cheap either! You can find her at www.netnanny.com.

Installation took a bit longer because of the size, but was easy nonetheless. Configuration was a snap, and I found that you could even choose to block online games—unique indeed.

There's also a paranoid setting that blocks all images and ads online, so it's good for parents who want kids to only see text online—but that's a little too old-fashioned for me!

Anyway, straight to the tests: the Nanny doesn't seem to have kept abreast with the times, and this was clear when it let a few obvious sites slip by unnoticed. Another indication of age

having caught up with this software was the fact that it refused to filter any images, and the most explicit of images just kept popping up in Google Image searches!

Internet slang, which your kids are likely to be using, just leaves the Nanny confused, and text blocking was abysmal! The only way it offered

me a challenge was when I set the filtering level to maximum—which, incidentally, means that only sites that are manually allowed can be viewed! It even blocked www.thinkdigit.com in this paranoid mode! The final nail in the coffin was that the Nanny doesn't seem to recognise Opera as a browser, and just let anything by!

Overall, this was a very unsatisfying experience, and to be honest, I expected more of a challenge from the Nanny. I think it's time she retired. Her “block everything or nothing” philosophy is certainly not what you're looking for in a content filter!

Optenet Web Filter

This is a software I stumbled across when reading through a few forums, and is certainly not a popular choice. However, I decided to include it based on a few reviews from people who seemed to know what they were talking about. At 17.7 MB, this software is almost as fat as the Nanny, and at \$39, just as expensive. I got the 15-day free trial from www.optenet.com, and found that installation and configuration was simple enough. After a reboot I was ready to pit my wits against it.

I was shocked to see that it refused to open the administration panel, which it was trying to do in my browser. I soon learnt that it probably uses some code that Opera can't understand, because when I pasted the address it was trying